

Online Banking

Online banking allows you to manage your money via the Internet—when and where you want. You can view all your banking transactions, move money, view and print your canceled checks, and pay bills online. You can also arrange to have your bank e-mail you when checks clear or your balance goes under a predetermined minimum. As time goes on, online banking continues to evolve. You used to just look at your accounts and download information. Then online savings accounts hit the scene with extremely attractive interest rates. Next, banks moved to checking and loans online. Things can only get better and better from here.

The main attraction to online banking is convenience. You can view your accounts and download information to your computer. Many people have enjoyed using online banks to balance their checkbooks as opposed to doing things the old-fashioned way. In addition, you can have an online bill-pay service write and mail checks for you—or just zap the money to your service providers electronically.

Online Offerings

Another attraction of online banking is competitive pricing. The first Internet bank accounts were savings accounts paying much more than brick-and-mortar banks paid. Some accounts even offer checks, ATM cards, and bill-pay with these high-yield accounts. Banks continue to offer more every year.

Most large banks offer secure online banking free. You can view your accounts, transfer money, and download data in most cases. Online bill-pay is often free as well, although some banks charge a modest fee (perhaps \$6 per month) or require you to keep a meaningful balance in your account for free bill-pay services. Some smaller banks offer limited functions only, such as the ability to view your balance and history online.

Even if you don't bank online, you may still use technology to make life easy. For example, you can use automatic debits to have payment for one or more of your bills automatically deducted from your checking account each